I am Adam Lanza's Mother

By Liza Long

INTRODUCTION

A horrific national tragedy occurred on December 14, 2012 -- the murder of 20 children and six adults at Sandy Hook Elementary School in Newtown, Connecticut – the tragedy has ignited a new discussion on violence in America. In kitchens and coffee shops across the country, we tearfully debate the many faces of violence in America: gun culture, media violence, lack of mental health services, overt and covert wars abroad, religion, politics and the way we raise our children.

Liza Long, a writer based in Boise, says it's easy to talk about guns. But it's time to talk about mental illness. While every family's story of mental illness is different, and we may never know the whole of the Lanzas' story, tales like this one need to be heard -- and families who live them deserve our help.

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MOTHER: Three days before 20-year-old Adam Lanza killed his mother, then opened fire on a classroom full of Connecticut kindergartners, my 13-year-old son Michael *(name changed)* missed his bus because he was wearing the wrong color pants.

MICHAEL: *(belligerent; angry)* I can wear these pants!

MOTHER: *(to Michael, calmly)* They are navy blue. Your school's dress code says black or khaki pants only.

MICHAEL: *(insistent)* They told me I could wear these. You're a stupid b****. I can wear whatever pants I want to. This is America. I have rights!

MOTHER: *(reasonably)* You can't wear whatever pants you want to. And you definitely cannot call me a stupid b*****. You're grounded from electronics for the rest of the day. Now get in the car, and I will take you to school.

(to audience) I live with a son who is mentally ill. I love my son. But he terrifies me. *(beat)* A few weeks ago, Michael pulled a knife and threatened to kill me and then himself after I asked him to return his overdue library books. His 7- and 9-year-old siblings knew the safety plan -- they ran to the car and locked the doors before I even asked them to. I managed to

get the knife from Michael, then methodically collected all the sharp objects in the house into a single Tupperware container that now travels with me. Through it all, he continued to scream insults at me and threaten to kill or hurt me.

That conflict ended with three burly police officers and a paramedic wrestling my son onto a gurney for an expensive ambulance ride to the local emergency room. The mental hospital didn't have any beds that day, and Michael calmed down nicely in the ER, so they sent us home with a prescription for Zyprexa and a follow-up visit with a local pediatric psychiatrist.

We still don't know what's wrong with Michael. Autism spectrum, ADHD, Oppositional Defiant or Intermittent Explosive Disorder have all been tossed around at various meetings with probation officers and social workers and counselors and teachers and school administrators. He's been on a slew of antipsychotic and mood-altering pharmaceuticals, a Russian novel of behavioral plans. Nothing seems to work.

At the start of seventh grade, Michael was accepted to an accelerated program for highly gifted math and science students. His IQ is off the charts. When he's in a good mood, he will gladly bend your ear on subjects ranging from Greek mythology to the differences between Einsteinian and Newtonian physics to Doctor Who. He's in a good mood most of the time. But when he's not, watch out. And it's impossible to predict what will set him off.

Several weeks into his new junior high school, Michael began exhibiting increasingly odd and threatening behaviors at school. We decided to transfer him to the district's most restrictive behavioral program, a contained school environment where children who can't function in normal classrooms can access their right to free public babysitting from 7:30-1:50 Monday through Friday until they turn 18.

The morning of the pants incident, Michael continued to argue with me on the drive. He would occasionally apologize and seem remorseful. Right before we turned into his school parking lot, he said . . .

MICHAEL: Look, Mom, I'm really sorry. Can I have video games back today?

MOTHER: No way. You cannot act the way you acted this morning and think you can get your electronic privileges back that quickly. *(to audience)* His face turned cold, and his eyes were full of calculated rage.

MICHAEL: Then I'm going to kill myself. I'm going to jump out of this car right now and kill myself.

MOTHER: *(beat)* That was it. After the knife incident, I [had] told him that if he ever said those words again, I would take him straight to the mental hospital, no ifs, ands, or buts. I did not respond, except to pull the car into the opposite lane, turning left instead of right.

MICHAEL: *(suddenly worried)* Where are you taking me? Where are we going?

MOTHER: You know where we are going.

MICHAEL: *(frantically)* No! You can't do that to me! You're sending me to hell! You're sending me straight to hell!

MOTHER: I pulled up in front of the hospital, frantically waving for one of the clinicians who happened to be standing outside. *(calling out to clinician)* Call the police. Hurry!

(to audience) Michael was in a full-blown fit by then, screaming and hitting. I hugged him close so he couldn't escape from the car. He bit me several times and repeatedly jabbed his elbows into my rib cage. I'm still stronger than he is, but I won't be for much longer.

The police came quickly and carried my son screaming and kicking into the bowels of the hospital. I started to shake, and tears filled my eyes as I filled out the paperwork -- "Were there any difficulties with. . . at what age did your child. . . were there any problems with. . . has your child ever experienced. . . does your child have. . ."

At least we have health insurance now. I recently accepted a position with a local college, giving up my freelance career because when you have a kid like this, you need benefits. You'll do anything for benefits. No individual insurance plan will cover this kind of thing.

For days, my son insisted that I was lying -- that I made the whole thing up so that I could get rid of him. The first day, when I called to check up on him, he said . . .

MICHAEL: *(on the phone)* I hate you. And I'm going to get my revenge as soon as I get out of here.

MOTHER: By day three, he was my calm, sweet boy again, all apologies and promises to get better. I've heard those promises for years. I don't believe them anymore.

On the intake form, under the question, "What are your expectations for treatment?" I wrote, "I need help." And I do. This problem is too big for me to handle on my own. Sometimes there are no good options. So, you just pray for grace and trust that in hindsight, it will all make sense.

I am sharing this story because I am Adam Lanza's mother. I am Dylan Klebold's and Eric Harris's mother. I am James Holmes's mother. I am Jared Loughner's mother. I am Seung-Hui Cho's mother. And these boys -- and their mothers -- need help. In the wake of another horrific national tragedy, it's easy to talk about guns. But it's time to talk about mental illness.

According to Mother Jones, since 1982, 61 mass murders involving firearms have occurred throughout the country. Of these, 43 of the killers were white males, and only one was a woman. *(Suggested update 1/26/2026)* According to Mother Jones, since 1982, 140* mass murders involving firearms have occurred throughout the country. Of these, 85 of the killers were white males, and only 4 were women. Mother Jones focused on whether the killers obtained their guns legally (most did). But this highly visible sign of mental illness should lead us to consider how many people in the U.S. live in fear, like I do.

When I asked my son's social worker about my options, he said that the only thing I could do was to get Michael charged with a crime.

SOCIAL WORKER: If he's back in the system, they'll create a paper trail. That's the only way you're ever going to get anything done. No one will pay attention to you unless you've got charges.

MOTHER: I don't believe my son belongs in jail. The chaotic environment exacerbates Michael's sensitivity to sensory stimuli and doesn't deal with the underlying pathology. But it seems

like the United States is using prison as the solution of choice for mentally ill people. According to Human Rights Watch, the number of mentally ill inmates in U.S. prisons quadrupled from 2000 to 2006, and it continues to rise -- in fact, the rate of inmate mental illness is five times greater (56 percent) than in the non-incarcerated population. *(Suggested update 1/26/2026)* According to ** The Prison Policy Initiative: *As of 2025-2026, over 37% to 44% of incarcerated people in U.S. state and federal prisons and local jails have a history of mental health issues, with up to 1 in 5 suffering from a serious mental illness. These high figures mean over 1 million people with mental health issues are currently incarcerated.* With state-run treatment centers and hospitals shuttered, prison is now the last resort for the mentally ill.

No one wants to send a 13-year-old genius who loves Harry Potter and his snuggle animal collection to jail. But our society, with its stigma on mental illness and its broken healthcare system, does not provide us with other options. Then another tortured soul shoots up a fast-food restaurant. A mall. A kindergarten classroom. And we wring our hands and say, "Something must be done."

I agree that something must be done. It's time for a meaningful, nation-wide conversation about mental health. That's the only way our nation can ever truly heal.
God help me. God help Michael. God help us all.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Liza Long
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AWARD HISTORY

2022 National Qualifier – MS
KS State Qualifier

Updated with current data from Mother Jones.com

** https://www.motherjones.com/politics/2012/12/mass-shootings-mother-jones-full-data/*

Updated with current data from The Prison Policy Initiative

*** https://www.prisonpolicy.org/research/mental_health/*

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